

SPAN 290gp, Fall 2026  
Introduction to Latin American and Iberian Studies  
MHP 101: Tue, Thu, 12:30-1:50 pm

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This course is an introduction to the cultural history of Latin America and the Iberian Peninsula from the early-modern period to the twenty-first century. Drawing on literature (fiction, poetry, autobiography) and visual culture (painting, film), the course analyzes works by consecrated writers and artists as well as by some less well-known figures. Although the order of our readings is to some extent chronological, the course is not intended as a traditional literary- or art-historical survey, but rather as an introduction to some of the issues at the heart of the interrelated fields of Hispanism and Latin American studies. We look at the concept of canonicity in the so-called Spanish Golden Age, the literary and visual representation of indigenous peoples in Latin America, the rise of anti-realist trends in the twentieth century on both sides of the Atlantic, and the ongoing artistic dialogue between Europe and Latin America. Departing from national rubrics, we also consider the pleasures and perils of reading and viewing Spanish and Latin American works without taking their place of origin into account. Most important, we also investigate the function of the arts not only as aesthetic objects or entertainment, but also as powerful tools of knowledge.

### Requirements

- Reading Notes (100 points)
- Essay 1 (100 points)
- Essay 2 (100 points)
- Midterm Exam (100 points)
- Final Exam (100 points)

### Learning Objectives

- Reflect on what Iberian and Latin American cultural history communicates about the human condition in the form of literature, painting, photography, and film.
- Be familiar with the cultural history of the Iberian Peninsula and Latin America, and some of their most significant authors, artists, and filmmakers, and be able to interpret texts by major and minor figures in that history.
- Cultivate a critical appreciation for the literary and visual canons of the Iberian Peninsula and Latin America, and understand the various esthetic and political criteria

deployed through the centuries for determining the enduring or shifting value of cultural creations.

- Understand the continuity between consecrated works of the Iberian and Latin American canons and their later manifestations on both sides of the Atlantic.
- Engage with such concepts as cultural tradition, legacy, autonomy, imperialism, hybridity, and globalization from multiple perspectives, and reflect on the ties that bind the Iberian Peninsula and Latin America (including the indigenous world) together and with other parts of the world, especially the United States.
- Learn to analyze primary sources such as literary and visual texts actively and creatively, and to think and write critically and persuasively about these texts.

### **Grading Scale**

|    |              |
|----|--------------|
| A  | 95-100       |
| A- | 90-94        |
| B+ | 87-89        |
| B  | 83-86        |
| B- | 80-82        |
| C+ | 77-79        |
| C  | 73-76        |
| C- | 70-72        |
| D+ | 67-69        |
| D  | 63-66        |
| D- | 60-62        |
| F  | 59 and below |

### **Course materials**

Readings to be distributed through BrightSpace.

## Provisional Schedule

Introduction to Course: 8/25

New Worlds:

8/27

- *El requerimiento*
- Christopher Columbus, "Digest of Columbus's Log-Book on his First Voyage Made by Bartolomé de las Casas"

9/1

- Hernán Cortés, Second Letter
- Octavio Paz, "The Sons of La Malinche"

Al-Andalus:

9/3

- María Rosa Menocal, *The Ornament of the World* (selections)
- Borges, "Averroes's Search"
- The Edict of Expulsion

9/8

- Antonio de Villegas, *The Abencerraje*

Siglo de oro:

9/10

- *Lazarillo de Tormes*

9/15

- Cervantes, *Don Quixote* (selections)
- Borges, "Pierre Menard"

Race and Gender in Colonial Spanish America:

9/17

- Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz, "Ballad 2" and "Redondilla 92"
- Manuel Fernández de la Cruz, "A Letter from Sor Filotea to Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz"
- Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz, "Response of the Poet to the Very Eminent Sor Filotea de la Cruz"

9/18: Essay 1

9/22

- Miguel Cabrera, Paintings
- Ilona Katzew, *Casta Painting: Images of Race in Eighteenth-Century Mexico* (selections)

The Wars of Independence

9/22

- Francisco Goya, *Los desastres de la Guerra* (images)

9/24

- Simón Bolívar, "Letter from Jamaica"

- Andrés Bello, “Address Delivered at the Inauguration of the University of Chile”
- 9/29:
- Midterm Review

10/1: MIDTERM (in class)

### The Birth of Postcolonial America

10/6

- Domingo de Sarmiento, Selections from *Civilization or Barbarism*

10/8: FALL RECESS

10/13

- Lucio V. Mansilla, *A Visit to the Ranquel Indians* (selections)
- Borges, “Story of the Warrior and the Captive”

### Our America:

10/15 (Guest lecture, P. Brodsky)

- José Martí, “Our América”
- Rubén Darío, “To Roosevelt”

1898

10/20

- Miguel de Unamuno, *The Tragic Sense of Life in Men and Nations* (selections)

10/22: No class (Professor traveling)

### Tales of Civilization and Barbarism:

10/27

- José Enrique Rodó, *Ariel* (selections)
- José Fernández Retamar, *Caliban* (selections)

10/29

- Castro, “Speech to Intellectuals”
- Film: Tomás Gutiérrez Alea, *Memories of Underdevelopment* (screened at home)

### Race and the Anthropological Imagination:

11/3

- José Vasconcelos, *The Cosmic Race* (selections)
- Oswald de Andrade, *Cannibalist Manifesto*

11/5

- Film: José Luis Sáenz de Heredia, *Raza* (selections screened during lecture)

### After the Spanish Republic I:

11/10—11/12

- Film: Guillermo del Toro, *Pan's Labyrinth*

### After the Spanish Republic II:

11/17—11/19 (Guest lecture, F. Rotger)

- Film: Pedro Almodóvar, *All About My Mother*

11/20: Essay 2

Literature Today:

11/24:

- Bolaño, *Amulet*

11/26: THANKSGIVING

12/1:

- Bolaño, *Amulet*

12/3: FINAL REVIEW

### Academic Integrity

[This language on Academic Integrity is required to be included on your syllabi.]

The University of Southern California is foremost a learning community committed to fostering successful scholars and researchers dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge and the transmission of ideas. Academic misconduct is contrary to this fundamental mission and includes any act of dishonesty in the submission of academic work (either in draft or final form), as well as cheating, plagiarism, fabrication (e.g., falsifying data), knowingly assisting others in acts of academic dishonesty, and any act that gains or is intended to gain an unfair academic advantage. Students are expected to uphold the highest standards of academic integrity in all coursework.

This course follows the expectations for academic integrity as stated in the USC Student Handbook. All students are expected to submit assignments that are original work and prepared specifically for the course/section in this academic term. Students may not submit work written by others or “recycle” work prepared for other courses without obtaining written permission from the instructor(s). Students suspected of academic misconduct will be reported to the Office of Academic Integrity.

Academic dishonesty has a far-reaching impact and is considered a serious offense against the university. Violations will result in a grade penalty, such as a failing grade on the assignment or in the course, and disciplinary action from the university, such as suspension or expulsion.

For more information about academic integrity see the Student Handbook, the Office of Academic Integrity’s website, and university policies on Research and Scholarship Misconduct.

Please ask your instructor if you are unsure what constitutes unauthorized assistance on an exam or assignment or what information requires citation and/or attribution.]

AI

This course aims to develop creative, analytical, and critical thinking skills. Therefore, all assignments should be prepared by the student working individually or in groups. Students may not have another person or entity complete any substantive portion of the assignment. Developing strong competencies in these areas will prepare you for a competitive workplace. Therefore, using AI-generated text, code, or other content is prohibited in this course, will be identified as plagiarism, and will be reported to the Office of Academic Integrity.

## **Statement on University Academic and Support Systems**

### Students and Disability Accommodations:

USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at [osas.usc.edu](http://osas.usc.edu). You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at [osasfrontdesk@usc.edu](mailto:osasfrontdesk@usc.edu).

### Student Financial Aid and Satisfactory Academic Progress:

To be eligible for certain kinds of financial aid, students are required to maintain Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) toward their degree objectives. Visit the Financial Aid Office webpage for undergraduate- and graduate-level SAP eligibility requirements and the appeals process.

### Support Systems:

Counseling and Mental Health - (213) 740-9355 – 24/7 on call

Free and confidential mental health treatment for students, including short-term psychotherapy, group counseling, stress fitness workshops, and crisis intervention.

988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline - 988 for both calls and text messages – 24/7 on call

The 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (formerly known as the National Suicide Prevention Lifeline) provides free and confidential emotional support to people in suicidal crisis or emotional distress 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, across the United States. The Lifeline consists of a national network of over 200 local crisis centers, combining custom local care and resources with national standards and best practices. The new, shorter phone number makes it easier for people to remember and access mental health crisis services (though the previous 1 (800) 273-8255 number will continue to function indefinitely) and represents a continued commitment to those in crisis.

Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention Services (RSVP) - (213) 740-9355(WELL) – 24/7 on call

Free and confidential therapy services, workshops, and training for situations related to gender- and power-based harm (including sexual assault, intimate partner violence, and stalking).

Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title IX (EEO-TIX) - (213) 740-5086

Information about how to get help or help someone affected by harassment or discrimination, rights of protected classes, reporting options, and additional resources for students, faculty, staff, visitors, and applicants.

Reporting Incidents of Bias or Harassment - (213) 740-2500

Avenue to report incidents of bias, hate crimes, and microaggressions to the Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title for appropriate investigation, supportive measures, and response.

The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) - (213) 740-0776

OSAS ensures equal access for students with disabilities through providing academic accommodations and auxiliary aids in accordance with federal laws and university policy.

USC Campus Support and Intervention - (213) 740-0411

Assists students and families in resolving complex personal, financial, and academic issues adversely affecting their success as a student.

Diversity, Equity and Inclusion - (213) 740-2101

Information on events, programs and training, the Provost's Diversity and Inclusion Council, Diversity Liaisons for each academic school, chronology, participation, and various resources for students.

USC Emergency - UPC: (213) 740-4321, HSC: (323) 442-1000 – 24/7 on call

Emergency assistance and avenue to report a crime. Latest updates regarding safety, including ways in which instruction will be continued if an officially declared emergency makes travel to campus infeasible.

USC Department of Public Safety - UPC: (213) 740-6000, HSC: (323) 442-1200 – 24/7 on call

Non-emergency assistance or information.

Office of the Ombuds - (213) 821-9556 (UPC) / (323) 442-0382 (HSC)

A safe and confidential place to share your USC-related issues with a University Ombuds who will work with you to explore options or paths to manage your concern.

Occupational Therapy Faculty Practice - (323) 442-2850 or [otfp@med.usc.edu](mailto:otfp@med.usc.edu)

Confidential Lifestyle Redesign services for USC students to support health promoting habits and routines that enhance quality of life and academic performance.